State Bond Referenda Questions

Referenda Questions 1 – 5 involve authorizing the State to borrow money through bonds and temporary notes to make capital investments **(Chapter 084 Public Laws 2026).**

What is a bond?

A bond is like a mortgage or loan. Just like people might borrow money to get an education or buy a home, the State is asking to borrow money from a lender with the promise to pay it back over time with interest. These questions are asking you for permission to borrow and invest in different areas of our state.

Here is a table of the bond proposals and their associated costs including principal and interest. Just as with a mortgage or loan, the total cost includes the principal amount borrowed and the amount of interest paid over the term of the bond. The total cost also includes any fees, printing, or underwriting expenses associated with issuing the bonds.

STATE BOND QUESTIONS	PRINCIPAL	INTEREST	TOTAL COSTS
1. Higher Education Facilities	$275,000,000	$166,333,250	$441,333,250
2. Housing and Homeownership	$120,000,000	$72,586,000	$192,586,000
3. Economic Development	$100,000,000	$60,483,750	$160,483,750
4. Cultural Economy	$50,000,000	$30,242,500	$80,242,500
5. Green Economy Bonds	$55,000,000	$33,267,500	$88,267,500
TOTAL BORROWING COSTS FOR ALL REFERENDA	$600,000,000	$362,913,000	$962,913,000

The total costs above are only estimates based on 20-year loans and an interest rate of 5%.

On the ballot, you will be asked:

"Shall the act passed by the General Assembly at the January 2026 session, allowing the State of Rhode Island to issue bonds, refunding bonds, and temporary notes to pay for the projects listed below, be approved, and the State be allowed to issue these bonds, refunding bonds, and temporary notes as outlined in the law?"

The following pages provide more information about each of the bond questions including their total estimated cost and project timetable. These estimated costs assume the bonds are gradually paid off with level payments over a 20-year period.

About Question 1:

What it will look like on the ballot:

1. HIGHER EDUCATION FACILITIES - $275,000,000

For capital improvements to higher education facilities, to be allocated as follows:

a. University of Rhode Island Integrated Health Building - $165,000,000

b. Rhode Island College Adams Library Renovations - $50,000,000

c. Community College of Rhode Island Workforce Innovation Center - $60,000,000

⬭ **Approve**

⬭ **Reject**

Approve

Your vote to "Approve" means that you support the State issuing $275,000,000 in general obligation bonds for improvements to higher education facilities.

Reject

Your vote to "Reject" means that you are against the State issuing $275,000,000 in general obligation bonds for improvements to higher education facilities.

Explanation and purpose of Question 1:

a) University of Rhode Island - Integrated Health Building - $165,000,000

Approval of this bond will provide one hundred and sixty-five million dollars ($165,000,000) to design and construct a new facility and associated infrastructure at the University of Rhode Island's Kingston Campus, which will significantly advance health education, clinical training, and workforce development. The Integrated Health Building will meet the growing demand for highly trained healthcare professionals and facilitate greater interdisciplinary collaboration across URI's health-related disciplines. It aligns with URI's commitment to health innovation, workforce development, and economic growth and will strengthen the state's healthcare workforce pipeline.

b) Rhode Island College - Adams Library Renovations - $50,000,000

Approval of this bond will provide fifty million dollars ($50,000,000) to finance the construction of a student success and career readiness center and renovations to the Adams Library. This project will reimagine the role of the college's central library into a modern hub for career readiness and academic achievement, helping to improve student outcomes, increase retention and completion rates, and accelerate pathways to employment.

c) Community College of Rhode Island - Workforce Innovation Center - $60,000,000

Approval of this bond will provide sixty million dollars ($60,000,000) to construct the Community College of Rhode Island Workforce Innovation Center at the Knight Campus in Warwick. The Workforce Innovation Center will serve as a centralized hub for workforce education and training, increasing Rhode Island's capacity to prepare students and workers for high-demand careers in advanced manufacturing, construction and the skilled trades, healthcare, information technology and cybersecurity, clean energy, transportation and logistics, and other growing industries. The facility will provide modern classrooms, specialized laboratories, and hands-on training spaces developed in partnership with employers to help address workforce shortages, expand career education opportunities, and strengthen Rhode Island's economy.

How much money will be borrowed?

$275,000,000

Project timetable:

a) University of Rhode Island Integrated Health Building construction is expected to be completed and the project ready for use in 2031.

b) Rhode Island College Adams Library renovation is expected to be completed and the project ready for use in 2030.

c) The Community College of Rhode Island Workforce Innovation Center construction is expected to commence in 2028. Construction is anticipated to be completed in 2030.

Useful life:

a) The University of Rhode Island estimates that the useful life of the Integrated Health Building will be approximately 50 years.

b) Rhode Island College estimates that the useful life of the renovated Adams Library building will be approximately 50 years.

c) The Community College of Rhode Island estimates that the useful life of the Workforce Innovation Center will be approximately 75 years.

Total cost:

PROJECT COSTS		COST OF ISSUANCE*	
Principal	**Interest****	**Principal**	**Interest****
$273,900,000	$165,667,917	$1,100,000	$665,333

TOTAL PROJECT AND ISSUANCE COSTS		
Principal	**Interest****	**Total Costs**
$275,000,000	$166,333,250	$441,333,250

** Cost of issuance estimated at 0.4% of principal issued.*
*** Assumes an interest rate of 5%, with bonds amortized with level payments over 20 years.*